

Reading Notebook

Kept by Ian Woodward, Silver Spring, Maryland

Notes on what I am reading

I keep this notebook for myself, a few lines on each book so the years do not blur together. Mum and I watch our mysteries at night, but the reading is mine, early mornings before the house wakes and late on the quiet nights. Lately it has been McCarthy and Steinbeck, with O'Brien and Proulx waiting on the shelf.

Cormac McCarthy, Blood Meridian

Third time through and it still takes something out of me. McCarthy writes violence the way scripture writes judgment, plain and total, no comfort offered. The judge is the most frightening character I have ever read because he is an idea more than a man. What keeps me coming back is the prose, those long unpunctuated lines that move like weather across the page. It is not a book I love so much as one I respect, the way you respect a hard country.

Cormac McCarthy, The Road

This one I cannot read the same way since the kids. A father and a son carrying the fire through the ash. Stripped of everything, what is left is the care between them, and that is the whole point. I think about the work I do, people who have lost their country the way those two lost the world, still walking, still carrying someone. It guts me and it steadies me at the same time.

John Steinbeck, East of Eden

Working through the collected Steinbeck and this is the heart of it. Timshel, thou mayest. The idea that a man is not fated, that he can choose, lands hard for me. I sit across from people whose whole case turns on whether a system will let them choose a life. Steinbeck believes in people without being naive about them. Cathy is proof he knew the dark; Samuel Hamilton is proof he chose the light anyway.

John Steinbeck, The Grapes of Wrath

The Joads on the road west, dignity holding even as everything is taken. Mum's people worked the mills in Pawtucket and she cleaned offices in DC for twenty years, so the working class spine of this book is not abstract to me. The last scene, I will not spoil it to my own notebook, but it is the most human thing Steinbeck ever wrote.

On the shelf next

Author	Title	Why
Tim O'Brien	The Things They Carried	Carrying, again; the theme finds me
Annie Proulx	Close Range	New England and hard country writing
John Steinbeck	Cannery Row	A lighter Steinbeck, for balance
Cormac McCarthy	Suttree	The one I have put off the longest

Why these writers and not others

People ask why I read such hard books after the days I have. The answer is that the soft ones do not tell me the truth. I sit across from people on the worst day of their lives and turn it into a filing. McCarthy and Steinbeck do not flinch from suffering, but they do not wallow either; they look straight at it and find the thread of dignity that runs through. That is the same thing I am trying to do at a desk in DC. The books are not an escape from the work. They are a rehearsal for it.

On reading with Mum, sort of

Mum does not read the novels, but we have the mysteries at night, the old reruns and the black-and-white serials. It is the same pleasure in a different key: a problem, a pattern, a resolution that feels earned. She catches the killer two scenes before I do, every time, and pretends she did not. Those nights are their own kind of literature, the two of us on the couch with the volume low so the kids can sleep.

The mysteries, for the record

Show	Why we love it
Murder, She Wrote	A sharp woman nobody underestimates twice
Broadchurch	The rewatch comfort show, grief done honestly
Black-and-white serials	What Mum grew up on, the old patient pacing
The cozy village mysteries	Low stakes, high craft, perfect for a tired night

A short list of lines I keep

Timshel, thou mayest. Steinbeck, on the freedom to choose.

Carry the fire. McCarthy, on what a father owes a son.

And he could not stop. Steinbeck, on the migrant road.

The dignity is in the trying. That one is mine, from the desk.

Books I want the kids to have someday

Not yet, they are too young for the hard ones, but I think about which books I want Michael and Lucy to find on the shelf when they are ready. For Michael, who carries quiet weight the way I did at his age, I would point to East of Eden, because he needs to know early that he is not fated, that he gets to choose. For Lucy, all light and color, maybe Cannery Row first, so she meets Steinbeck laughing before she meets him grieving. There is time. The books will wait for them the way they waited for me.

For	Book	The reason
Michael	East of Eden	You are not fated; you choose
Michael	The Things They Carried	On duty and what we carry
Lucy	Cannery Row	Steinbeck with a lighter heart
Both, later	The Road	On love when everything else is gone

The reading log, this year so far

I keep a rough log so I can see the year take shape. Nothing strict, just what I finished and what I set down for later. The pace slows when the caseload climbs and picks back up over the summer break, but the line never stops entirely, and that is the whole point of writing it down.

Month	Book	Status
January	Blood Meridian (reread)	Finished, third time
February	The Road (reread)	Finished, slow on purpose
October	East of Eden	In progress, the long middle
November	The Grapes of Wrath	Queued, after Eden
Winter	The Things They Carried	On the nightstand, waiting

On hard books and a soft heart

There is a thing people get wrong about reading dark writers. They assume it hardens you. For me it is the opposite. Spending a few pages inside someone else's worst hour, written by a person who refuses to look away, makes me gentler at the desk the next morning, not colder. The trick the great ones pull off is to hold suffering and dignity in the same hand. That is the exact muscle the work asks of me, and a novel is a safe place to keep it in shape on a quiet night.

What I tell the kids about reading

Lucy already reads above her grade and treats a library card like a season pass. Michael reads the way he does everything, quietly and all the way to the bottom of the thing. What I tell them both is the same: you do not have to love a book to be changed by it, and you are allowed to put one down and come back in ten years. The shelf is patient. I tell them the writers I love are not homework, they are company, the kind that does not flinch when you finally tell the truth about a hard day. Then I leave them alone to find their own, because a reading life that someone else assigns is not a reading life, it is a chore, and chores get abandoned the day you are free of them.

The morning habit

I do most of this reading in the half hour before the coffee, after the medications and before the house stirs. It is the only time of day that belongs to no one but me. Some mornings it is only a page. But a page a day is a book a season, and over a year that is the difference between a man who reads and a man who used to. I intend to stay the first kind, however full the calendar gets. O'Brien is next, and I already know he is going to undo me, because carrying things is the theme that finds me in every book I pick up. Maybe that is just what it is to be the one who holds the household together. You learn to carry, and you learn to read about others who carry, and somehow it makes the load lighter to know it is an old and human thing.